Another effect of India's PNE of 1974 was the acceleration of Pakistan's nuclear programme. Pakistan's pursuit of a nuclear weapon capability actually dates back to the 1960s—when it began to receive civilian nuclear assistance from various foreign actors—and among its biggest advocates was Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. Bhutto's logic of pursuing nuclear weapons was driven by a few factors, among them the belief that India would imminently follow China's 1964 test, his scepticism of the US alliance, his concerns about a non-proliferation regime closing off the nuclear option, and India's growing military capabilities. In a 1965 interview, Bhutto famously declared that Pakistan would produce a nuclear bomb 'even if we have to feed on grass and leaves'. [25] Upon becoming prime minister after the 1971 war, Bhutto placed the Pakistan Atomic Energy Commission (PAEC) under his direct control. In January 1972, he directed them to simultaneously produce plutonium through reprocessing, enrich uranium, and develop weapon designs. By March 1972, PAEC Chairman Munir Ahmad Khan presented plans that Bhutto quickly approved. From the outset, Pakistan's efforts benefited from Chinese assistance, including work on the Karachi Nuclear Power Plant (KANUPP) in the early 1970s. [26]

It was after India's PNE that A.Q. Khan—a Pakistani metallurgist working in the Netherlands—wrote to Bhutto, offering help with producing highly enriched uranium. In December 1975, Khan stole centrifuge designs from his employer and left the Netherlands. In 1976, he formally joined Pakistan's nuclear programme. [27] The same year, China and Pakistan signed an agreement for bilateral nuclear cooperation. [28] In 1981, Pakistan received 50 kilograms of highly enriched uranium and a 1966-vintage bomb design from China. In exchange, China was allowed to reverse engineer parts that Pakistan had acquired, including quite possibly A.Q. Khan's centrifuges. Khan also benefited from lax export controls, particularly in Europe, acquiring important parts from Switzerland, the Netherlands, and elsewhere. By the late 1970s and early 1980s, Pakistan's nuclear activities were well-known to others, including in the United States, with Zia and A.Q. Khan openly boasting of their capabilities. [29]